Yousef Khudher

Cybersecurity Expert | Purple Team Specialist | Security Operations Leader

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Languages: Arabic (Native), English (Professional Working Proficiency)

PROFESSIONAL SUMMARY

Purple Team specialist and co-founder with a decade of hands-on technical work since 2016, securing a national-scale environment of 1,000+ local and public-facing systems, 100+ servers, thousands of endpoints, and millions of end users. Cut SOC false positives from 60% to 15% through systematic detection tuning, and delivered 341+ red team and blue team assessment reports to date, bridging adversary simulation with detection engineering against the MITRE ATT&CK framework. Holder of all 14 OffSec certifications, a combination held by very few professionals globally, plus 36 total industry certifications including ISO/IEC 27001 and ISO/IEC 27701 Lead Auditor. Ranked 1st in Iraq and 19th globally at HTB Cyber Apocalypse 2025 among 18,000+ players. Discovered and responsibly disclosed 570+ vulnerabilities across HackerOne and global bug bounty platforms, plus 100+ more under contracted security engagements with Iraqi companies. Author of open-source offensive and defensive security tooling in Python, C, and C#.

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Private Company (Confidential)
Iraq | 2025 – Present | Full-time

Security Operations Leader, Red Team — Co-Founder
May 2026 – Present

- Co-founded the venture and lead a team of 4–5 security engineers, directing red team strategy and full-scope adversary emulation engagements.
- Plan and execute red team operations covering initial access, privilege escalation, lateral movement, and post-exploitation across enterprise environments.
- Build and maintain offensive tooling and attack infrastructure including C2 frameworks, redirectors, and custom payloads for OPSEC-safe operations.
- Identified and responsibly disclosed 100+ vulnerabilities under contracted security engagements with Iraqi companies, assessing production applications including Mantaqty (Codion Solutions), Linkchi for Software Solutions, FOR YOU MARKET, and Shaghlaty.
- Lead client-facing offensive engagements and present findings and remediation roadmaps to executive stakeholders.

Application Security Specialist / Penetration Tester / Testing Team Leader
2025 – Present

- Lead application security engagements assessing web and mobile applications for OWASP Top 10 and business logic vulnerabilities.
- Coordinate test coverage across the team, manage engagement timelines, and deliver findings to stakeholders.
- Develop custom testing methodologies and internal tooling to improve assessment quality and throughput.

Cybersecurity Specialist, Purple Team · SOC Engineer
Ministry of Interior, Iraq | December 2024 – Present | Full-time

- Secure a national-scale environment spanning 1,000+ local and public-facing systems, 100+ servers, thousands of endpoints, and millions of end users.
- Reduced SOC false positive rate from 60% to 15% through systematic detection tuning, sharply cutting analyst alert fatigue and freeing capacity for genuine threats.
- Delivered 341+ red team and blue team assessment reports to date, covering offensive findings, detection gap analysis, and remediation guidance.
- Operate as SOC engineer and cross-layer security advisor across network, endpoint, application, and infrastructure defense.
- Bridge Red and Blue Team operations, validating detection coverage against the MITRE ATT&CK framework through adversary simulation.
- Perform threat hunting and incident response using ELK SIEM; review and report vulnerability scan findings across the estate.
- Coordinate compliance audit evidence aligned with ISO/IEC 27001 and COBIT frameworks.

Red Team Penetration Tester
Ministry of Interior, Iraq (same employer) | 2025 – April 2026 | 8 months

- Conducted red team engagements and offensive penetration tests against enterprise infrastructure and applications, emulating real-world adversary tradecraft.
- Fed offensive findings directly into purple team detection-tuning work, closing the loop between attack and defense.

Penetration Tester
AMC, Iraq | May 2024 – January 2025 | 9 months

- Conducted internal and external penetration tests across enterprise systems and networks.
- Developed custom security tooling in Python and C++ to automate vulnerability discovery.

SOC Engineer
AMC, Iraq | November 2023 – April 2024 | Full-time

- Monitored security events, triaged alerts, and performed incident response using SIEM tooling.
- Developed detection playbooks to standardize and accelerate analyst response.

Independent Security Consultant and Application Developer
Self-employed | 2018 – Present

- Advise companies across Iraq and the MENA region on security posture, control gaps, and governance (ISO/IEC 27001, ISO/IEC 27701, PCI-DSS, NIST), delivering vulnerability assessments and penetration tests with formal reports.
- Design and build websites and custom software for regional clients with security hardening built in from the start.
- Develop bespoke automation tooling that reduces manual effort and headcount required while improving output consistency.

Network Administrator and Network Engineer
Almadar ISP / Freelance, Iraq | 2022 – 2023

- Administered live ISP production network infrastructure: routing, switching, DNS/ARP/TCP-IP, and firewall configuration, alongside call-center IT support.

Cybersecurity Competition Judge and Supervisor
Ministry of Interior and Ministry of Communications, Iraq | 2024 – 2025 | Part-time

- Supervised and judged three national-level cybersecurity competitions on behalf of Iraqi government ministries: two for the Ministry of Interior (2024–2025) and one for the Ministry of Communications (2025).

CTF Supervisor, National Internship Program
MOI Cybersecurity Directorate, Iraq | 2024 – 2025

- Designed and supervised a nationwide internship CTF program with approximately 500 participating students from across Iraq.

Bug Bounty Security Researcher
HackerOne and Regional Platforms, Independent | 2022 – Present

- Discovered and responsibly disclosed 570+ vulnerabilities ranging from Critical to Medium severity across global bug bounty programs.
- Assessed web applications, APIs, and network infrastructure; delivered detailed proof-of-concept reports with remediation guidance.

Academic Security Project Supervisor and Research Assistant
North Technical University and University of Mosul, Iraq | 2019 – Present | Part-time

- Designed and supervised 100+ Bachelor's, Master's, and PhD projects in network security and cybersecurity, covering IDS/IPS, secure communications, and Arduino/Raspberry Pi hardware security with custom PCB design; all achieved Excellent grades.
- Mentor learners and junior engineers across UX/UI, databases, and system optimization; perform reverse engineering and vulnerability testing on APIs and applications as part of mentoring engagements (2016 – Present).

EARLIER EXPERIENCE

IT Specialist to Senior Data Entry Clerk, AMC, Iraq (2021–2023) — Processed 5,000+ records daily into CRM/ERP at 99% accuracy; created standardized templates that improved team productivity 20% and reduced data errors 10%; mentored 4 new clerks and was promoted for exceeding quality targets.

Freelance Software and Web Development, Self-employed (2016–2021) — Built production mobile applications in the **Flutter** framework for local companies and ran a website-development-as-a-service business delivering **WordPress** sites and custom software for retail and small companies; performed bug bounty penetration testing for local companies and built custom pentest tooling; developed Minecraft mods and shader packs in Java.

OPEN SOURCE SECURITY TOOLING

SecureIntake (C#, Avalonia) — Cross-platform defensive GUI for safe triage of inbound files. Enforces allow-lists, inspects PDF and OOXML for risky features, runs fail-closed AV scanning (ClamAV/Defender), AES-GCM encrypts accepted output, and emits JSON audit logs tagged to MITRE ATT&CK.

Open-RedirIN (Python) — Detection tool for open redirect vulnerabilities in web applications.

lfi-hammer (Python) — Local File Inclusion scanner for real-world web targets.

Wadvancescanner (Python) — Web application scanner performing port discovery, enumeration, and vulnerability surfacing.

Advanced-Firewall, endpoint-firewall, IFire (Python, C) — Endpoint and network firewall tooling defending against DDoS, DNS spoofing, and ARP spoofing, with live rule management.

TECHNICAL SKILLS

Security Operations: Purple Team Operations, Adversary Emulation, Penetration Testing, Red Team, Blue Team, Threat Hunting, Incident Response, Vulnerability Management, SIEM (ELK, Splunk), SOC Operations, Malware Analysis

Frameworks and Standards: MITRE ATT&CK, NIST CSF, ISO/IEC 27001, ISO/IEC 27701, COBIT, OWASP, PTES, GDPR, PCI-DSS

Offensive Security: Web Application Exploitation, LFI, SSRF, Open Redirect, Active Directory Attacks, Wireless Attacks, Post-Exploitation, Lateral Movement, Privilege Escalation

Cloud and Infrastructure: AWS, Azure, GCP, Docker, Kubernetes, IAM Exploitation, CI/CD Pipeline Attacks, IaC Misconfiguration, Fortinet, Cisco, MikroTik

Tools: Burp Suite, Metasploit, Nmap, Nessus, Wireshark, Cobalt Strike, BloodHound, Impacket, SQLMap

Programming: Python, Bash, PowerShell, C, C++, C#, Dart (Flutter), Java, JavaScript

CERTIFICATIONS (36 TOTAL)

Offensive Security (OffSec), all 14: OSCE3, OSCP+, OSCP, OSEP, OSWE, OSED, OSWP, OSWA, OSDA, OSTH, OSIR, KLCP, OSCC-SJD, OSCC-SEC

CyberWarfare Labs: CRTA, MCRTA, MCBTA, DO-RTA, CRT-ID, CRTOM

Governance and Compliance: ISO/IEC 27001:2022 Lead Auditor, ISO/IEC 27701:2025 Lead Auditor

Network and Infrastructure: Cisco CCNA, Cisco CCNP, MikroTik MTCNA, Fortinet NSE3, Fortinet FCA, Aviatrix MCNA

Blue Team and SOC: OffSec SOC100 (100% score), eLearnSecurity eCIR, CSEDP, CNSP

EDUCATION

Bachelor of Engineering, Computer Engineering

University of Mosul, Iraq

- Final-year project: Intrusion Detection System (IDS) monitoring live network traffic to detect ARP spoofing, flooding, and TCP/TFTP anomalies using ML-enhanced algorithms. Graduated with Excellent grade.

CTF AND COMPETITION ACHIEVEMENTS

1st in Iraq, 19th Globally — HTB Cyber Apocalypse 2025, 18,000+ players worldwide, competed solo

52nd of 796 teams — Global Cyber Skills Benchmark CTF 2025, 77 of 103 challenges, 36,675 points (HackTheBox)

51st of 663 RITSEC CTF • **55th of 3,175** EC-Council Hackerverse • **Top 61 of 1,668** DownUnderCTF 6 • **Top Rank** VishwaCTF 2026